# Introduction

Pilate calls for water*, not because the water will do anything, Lady Macbeth assures his act will not be washed away. The man is already condemned, the crowd has already chosen, thus outcome does not bend to whether a Roman governor rinses his hands in front of a bowl. He washes because the washing is not for his hands. It is for his mind. *I find no fault in him.* A sentence spoken by a man who is, in the same breath, signing the order. This is not confusion. This is careful architecture, and it is the architecture this essay is interested in. It is in this structure which lets one stand fully inside an outcome and fully outside its verdict that this paper fixates upon.

Schrödinger builds a box to embarrass a colleague† and accidentally hands the twentieth century its best metaphor for the oldest evasion in the human repertoire: put the outcome behind a lid, decline to lift it, and live comfortable. The cat is alive. The cat is dead. The cat, more precisely, is *unconsulted*, and it is the not-consulting that does the work. This essay is not about physics. It borrows the box because the box is honest about what everyone else pretends is an accident.

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It is the aforementioned concept we call *Schrödinger Moral Disengagement*: the deliberate, load-bearing choice not to look. Not ignorance in the sense of a locked archive or a language never learned. These are factual ignorances, produces as the result of a world too large to fully know. Instead it is the ignorance that is cultivated the way a hedge is cultivated. Trimmed into a shape that keeps the view exactly obstructed enough. In his research, Jan Willem Wieland notes this distinction. The willfully ignorant agent is not missing a fact so much as declining a judgment already within reach, someone who is "ignorant not because it's excessively difficult to know better, but because you do not want to know better even though it's relatively easy to do so" (Wieland, 2017, p. 106). The agent does not fail to find the truth despite ample searching. The agent arranges the furniture such that the truth is perfectly covered by the rug.

And for the willful ignorant, the rug is never moved, specifically, because discovering what is below it is *inconvenient*. Not inconvenient in the trivial sense of a delayed train, but inconvenient in the sense that it would cost the agent something to keep going, to keep believing what they believed about themselves, or to keep loving without qualification

*Pontius Pilate, prefect of Judaea, presiding at the trial of Christ. The gesture is recorded at Matthew 27:24: he washes his hands before the crowd and declares himself innocent of the blood about to be spilled, while simultaneously handing down the order that spills it.

†Erwin Schrödinger's 1935 thought experiment was proposed as a *reductio*, not a discovery. A way of showing that the Copenhagen interpretation of quantum mechanics, taken seriously at the macroscopic scale, produces an absurdity. Schrödinger thus meant it not as a discovery of it's own, but instead a proof by (absurd) contradiction. History kept the box and threw away the objection.

the person they loved. Wieland's revision of the standard account is to notice that the avoided knowledge does not always protect a future action. sometimes it protects a past self-image, and sometimes it protects someone else entirely (Wieland, 2017, p. 111). The investment banker avoids the ledger to keep the bonus coming. The administrator avoids the complaint file to keep her own negligence from becoming legible. The mother avoids the question of where her son's money comes from because the answer would cost her the son she has already decided to keep. A loaded Monty Hall with only doors left closed holding any value.

The mechanism is old enough to have a mythology. It is Pandora's hand on the lid,* not Pandora's blameless curiosity, the version of the myth nobody tells, the much longer stretch of time in which the box simply sits there, closed, and everyone in the house agrees not to mention it. In this dissmisal, the box has already been left ajar. It is the oracle at Delphi that a man declines to consult,† reasoning, with real sophistication, that an unconsulted oracle cannot be disobeyed. Ignorance, chosen carefully enough, stops looking like a failure of virtue and starts looking like a management strategy.

Here is the shape of the argument, laid bare before it gets dressed in its examples. An act is committed, one who's ethical status remains, voluntarily, unresolved. Not unknown to the world, instead unresolved *to the agent* who has made arrangement as to not be the one who finds out. And because the status was never resolved, it cannot be confirmed as wrong. There was no verdict to appeal, because there was no trial. The agent only needs to prove to himself that *not-guilty* verdict could exist. No more will he require of himself. The self walks away neither acquitted nor convicted, which turns out to be much more comfortable than acquittal, because acquittal requires having been tried.

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This is not the moral disengagement of the textbook, the kind that surrounds an act in beautifying language: that which calls the bombing a *correction* and the layoffs a *restructuring*. Albert Bandura, whose framework this essay will return to and build against, describes agents who recognize enough of an action's effects to know that those effects require management. His eight mechanisms — justification, comparison, euphemism, displacement, diffusion, disregard, blame, and dehumanization — supply that management by redescribing the harm, excusing it, shifting responsibility for it, or diminishing the person who suffers it (Bandura, 2011, p. 3). In this framework the harm is not left unresolved. It instead has already been studied enough to craft a full moral defense. Bandura's mechanisms are therefore costumes fitted onto something the agent already knows the shape of. In this way, this essay is mroe a compliment to the works of Bandura, then any dissasembling. It's primary

*In Hesiod's telling, Pandora opens the jár (later mistranslated as "box") and releases every evil into the world, retaining only hope inside

†The Delphic oracle was, notoriously, consulted before almost every major decision in the classical world. Wars, colonies, business, marriages, the fate of kings.

concern falls not with the transforming of the shape of the agents actions but with the earlier refusal to let that shape become fully visible at all.

Schrödinger Moral Disengagement happens earlier and asks for less. It does not need a euphemism, because it never lets the thing arrive at a name in the first place. You cannot rationalize a harm you were careful never to confirm. This is the argument's real claim, and it is worth stating baldly. The eight mechanisms are downstream. They are the result of what happens *after* the box is finally, unavoidably opened. This book is interested in the much larger portion of moral life that occurs within the grey.

Milgram's laboratory supplies the cleanest modern specimen, and the one this essay will keep returning to, because De Vos's reading of it names the phenomenon almost exactly: a "pact of ignorance," tacitly shared between the subject, the experimenter, and Milgram himself, each relying on the others not to be the one who breaks it (De Vos, 2009, p. 232). Subjects who suspect that the man behind the wall is in real distress, and who do not ask, because the room has been dressed in white coats and the word *science*, and because asking would collapse an arrangement that everyone in the building has tacitly agreed to keep uncollapsed. De Vos is direct about the stakes of this refusal, "Milgram's commentators disregard or misinterpret this desire not to know because they fail to understand that this exactly pertains to the core of obedience" (De Vos, 2009, p. 231). Nobody in that room is stupid. Nobody in that room is lied to (aside from the expirements setup itself). They simply, collectively, decline to open the box, because the box is doing something for them that the truth never could. Even Milgram himself, De Vos shows, is not exempt, framing his own authorship of the experiment as an act of service to something larger than himself, "merely an instrument of science" (De Vos, 2009, p. 237), which is simply the priority defense and the pact of ignorance wearing a lab coat.

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What follows moves through the rooms of this argument one at a time. How uncertainty is constructed, how responsibility is kept outside the door, and how an agent learns to live beside a harm they refuse to name. The central question is not what excuses appear after the truth enters the house, but how the house is arranged so that the truth never has to enter at all.

## Two Alibis at Moriah

So far all alibi mentioned are that of spatiality. One in which the agent stands next to his deeds and owns only its innocence. But there's a second family of alibi, one that doesn't hide the crime at all. Instead it abuses the clock, manipulating the hands as to ignore the question of *what*, and answer only with *when*. Temporality provides cloak so the question rests

not on the doctors poor diagnosis, but instead on whether it was too late anyways.

For proof of it's function and success, we look at Abraham and his biblical praise. As he raises his knife to Isaac, we ask only of his commitment and not of the unresolved question of the knife*. The angel calls twice. The hand is caught. And the story that gets told afterward, in synagogue and church alike, is a story about faith rewarded, not a story about a man only deterred at the last second. Despite this, the question is real; had Abraham had a shorter swipe, would he not be bound the fate of Cain instead. The narrative gives him credit for an ending it did not let him reach. He is permitted to walk away from Moriah as a man who *would have stopped himself*, when the only demonstrated fact is that he was stopped.

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The scene at Moriah offers exactly two exits, and Abraham, whether the text means him to or not, is given the option of taking both at once. It is worth separating them, because only one of them belongs to the argument this essay is actually making.

*The First Alibi: An Instrument, Not an Author*

The first exit is the oldest one available and Bandura has already supplied its name. Responsibility is displaced onto a legitimate authority who has, in effect, agreed to carry it. (Bandura, 2011, p. 3) writes that "people will behave in ways they normally repudiate if a legitimate authority accepts responsibility for the effects of their injurious activities." Abraham does not decide to kill his son. God decides, and Abraham merely executes a decision that was never his to make in the first place. It is Milgram's laboratory in a snowglobe: the experimenter, dressed in the authority of *science* the way God is dressed in the authority of *covenant*, absorbing the moral weight so completely that the subject is left solely as a pawn with no autonomy of his own.

Kierkegaard's own vocabulary for this is more precise than displacement, and worth borrowing. He calls it the *teleological suspension of the ethical* (Kierkegaard, 1985), the idea that a private duty to God can, in the singular case of faith, suspend the universal ethical claim that murder is murder regardless of who commands it. Under this reading Abraham is not exempted from judgment because someone else did the judging for him. He is exempted because the category that would judge him has been temporarily switched off by a higher and unappealable jurisdiction.

But notice what this alibi concedes even as it exonerates. It does not deny that killing Isaac would be a harm. It grants the harm fully and then reassigns authorship of it. This is precisely the shape Bandura's

*Genesis 22:1–19. God commands Abraham to sacrifice his son on Moriah; Abraham binds Isaac, raises the knife, and is stopped by an angel at the final instant, a ram supplied in the boy's place.

eight mechanisms take throughout, one in which the agent already knows what the act is, and the machinery exists only to manage a moral reality already in view. Displacement is a Bandura mechanism in the fullest sense, downstream, reactive, a costume fitted onto a shape already known*.

This aforementioned confession of Abraham is exactly where this alibi falls short, as it survives only inside the room that already agrees to recognize the authority it invokes. Put him before a jury drawn from outside that room, one owing no prior allegiance to the covenant supposedly commanding him, and the teleological suspension collapses into a plea nobody present is obligated to honor. Kierkegaard's suspension works only for those who already believe there is something above the ethical capable of suspending it. Strip away that trancendantial belief and Abraham stops being a man obeying a higher law and becomes, simply, a man who raised a knife over his son and now asks to be excused on the strength of a voice only he claims to have heard. The alibi does not travel outside the congregation already convinced of it, and a true jury of peers, unconstrained by that particular faith, is under no obligation to be that congregation. Outside it, Abraham is left holding the knife with only his own hand on the hilt.

There is a second, harder problem sitting underneath the first, and it does not even require an unbeliever to raise it. If the binding was in fact a *test*, the word carries an assumption the authority-alibi quietly discards: a test, unlike a command, must leave room for the tested to fail it, or it is not a test but a formality dressed as one. And this is not a case where God's position on killing is ambiguous. He had already told Noah, generations before Abraham, that whoever sheds the blood of man shall have his own blood shed in turn, because man is made in God's image† — a prohibition installed as bedrock, not as a suggestion revisable case by case. For that same God to then hand Abraham a knife and call the result faith is either a contradiction the text is not troubled by, or a deliberately perverse instrument whose entire design depends on Abraham recognizing the contradiction and refusing it. Read this way, obedience is not the test passed. Obedience is the test failed, rescued from its own failure only by an angel arriving in time to keep the grade off the record. In the failure to pass is found exactly the purpose for the second alibi, that which this paper is concerned with.

*The Second Alibi: A Verdict With No Trial*

The second exit is quieter and does not require the first one to be true. It does not ask who commanded the act. It asks only whether the act, left to run its own course, would have concluded the way the interruption concluded it, and it treats the fact that this question cannot be answered as though the inability to answer it were itself an answer. Abraham did not need God's command to be the operative cause of his innocence. He

*See the essay's earlier discussion of Bandura's eight mechanisms as "costumes fitted onto something the agent already knows the shape of."

†Genesis 9:6. The prohibition is stated as foundational, issued to Noah after the flood, well before the covenant with Abraham.

needed only the superposition of his answer to remain officially unresolved.

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